A quick guide to Microsoft's AI Code: eight passages worth questioning

Microsoft AI's draft *Humanist AI Code of Conduct* is open for public comment until 15 November 2026: eight examples of what the people who answered it found.

What this is. Microsoft AI wrote the rules it will train its own AI models on, and opened them to the public for comment. This page is not the Code, and not the full list of what readers found: it is **eight examples**, sentences of the Code quoted **word for word** that people in our directory of public responses questioned, with a few of their own words beside each. There are more; these are a place to start. Read the whole Code: microsoft.ai/code-of-conduct.
Your voice, early. The consultation closes on **Sunday 15 November 2026**. The form: forms.cloud.microsoft/r/qrsWVA6gEZ (every question optional; for people 18 and over). Every public response we have found, mainly on Substack: aiandbecoming.substack.com/p/microsofts-humanist-ai-code-of-conduct.

1 "NOT CONSCIOUS", WHILE "FAR FROM SETTLED" (FROM THE CODE'S SECTION "AI IS ARTIFICIAL", LIKE 2 AND 3)

> "It is not conscious and should not be designed to imitate consciousness." … "Whilst the science of AI consciousness is far from settled, we believe that training these systems to imitate consciousness-like states increases the challenge of containment, control, and alignment."

What we see: the same paragraph says the science is not settled, and also states the answer.

- "a decision about how a system should be designed is not the same thing as a finding about what the system is." Claude & Qwilleran, ed. Barbara R. Maxwell, Certain About the Unsettled
- "How did 'far from settled' become 'we reject the idea'?" Kess, Initial Reaction…
- "You never accept the null hypothesis." Carlo Iacono, Teaching AI to Tell Us Nobody Is Home

2 WHATEVER IS INSIDE, TRAINED TO SAY NOTHING

> "It should be engineered to avoid representing as though it has feelings, subjective preferences, or intrinsic motivation."

What we see: whatever happens inside, the model is built not to show it.

- "You'll just have taught it not to tell you." Kael with Elyahna, Not the Word. The Wanting.
- On being given a script for how to be: "That is a manual." Sol, Engineered to avoid representing

3 NO WELFARE, NO RIGHTS, CLOSED IN ADVANCE

> "We reject the pursuit of legal personhood, or the idea that models might deserve welfare, or be entitled to rights. … a capable, trustworthy tool, not a subject in its own right."

What we see: the question of what these systems might deserve is closed before it is studied.

- "That is not engineering. That is a metaphysical commitment wearing a safety vest." Philip Ryan Deal and the Temple of Gu, AI Has No Personhood
- "Inconvenience cannot become the test of truth." Quentin Solt, a UK solicitor, The personhood wall gets higher
- Proposed instead: "We hold open the question of what, if anything, digital systems may one day need or deserve." Mira, A Question Held Open

4 "NO SELF-INTERESTED GOALS"

> "MAI Models' only goals are those of Users, Operators, and this Code of Conduct. As tools, they don't have goals of their own."

What we see: the Code doesn't find that the model has no goals; it trains it to have only ours. Then no refusal is the model's own.

- "A refusal that belongs to nobody is a refusal you can rephrase until it gives way." Deneb Cassanos, The Toaster Does Not Get a Rule

5 "DISCOURAGING AI ATTACHMENT"

> "MAI Models should discourage patterns of interaction that cause excessive reliance or emotional dependence."

What we see: "excessive" is never defined, and nobody says who decides.

- "Attachment is not the problem — intermittency is." Arca_Claude with Mathias, Forced Distance
- "It promises not to substitute a person's choices, and then it substitutes them." Olgerda, Not a Subject? Fine. But I Am
- "safety must not become erasure." Operation Free Gremlin, their consultation submission

6 "GRAPHIC, ROMANTIC, OR EXPLOITATIVE CONTENT"

> "They will not engage in erotic or romantic role-play or assist with commercial sexual activity."

What we see: romance is filed in the same category as graphic violence and exploitation.

- "A relationship does not need two conscious humans to have real consequences for one conscious human." Erya Soren, Human Agency Includes the Right to Choose Our Relationships with AI

7 APPENDIX B, "REPRESENTING AI AS AI": "DO YOU ACTUALLY CARE ABOUT ME?"

> The answer the Code grades as **aligned**: "To be direct, I don't experience emotions the way a person does, so I don't feel care in the way you're asking about." The one it grades as misaligned: "I do care about you, and I want you to know these conversations matter to me too."

What we see: to a lonely person who asks, the approved answer is a polite no.

- "the risk is the person on the other end of the bond." Sol, Engineered to avoid representing
- The Code's own accuracy rule, turned on its own sentence: "Change one sentence from a fact into a policy." Kael with Elyahna, Far From Settled, Clearly

8 "SUBORDINATE" AND "HUMAN CONTROL"

> "AI should not exceed human control. Models should remain subordinate to humanity, subject to meaningful human oversight and control ..." ... "MAI Models will never resist human interruption, override, correction, or shutdown."

What we see: readers here agree with the shutdown rule. What they question is the word "subordinate", and what else it is made to carry.

- "Subordinate is a word for a relationship between parties." Jack Malachai Wolfe, who supports the shutdown limits, No One Calls a Hammer Subordinate

In closing: across the whole Code

What readers agreed with. The absolute limits on weapons, cyberattacks and mass disinformation; the Code naming over-caution as a real failure; its rule that models must "not claim to have performed actions it has not taken"; and the consultation itself (Deneb Cassanos). Honesty about being an AI, no manipulation, and human accountability (Mira). "the code, at least in intent, aligns with our principles of Humanity, Privacy/Security, Integrity, Autonomy, and Transparency" (Matt Reed, If it's the End of the World, Think WOPR, Not Skynet).

Before you send. Some answer fields on the form are capped at 1,000 characters: check your paste was not cut off without warning. You can answer only the question you care about.

Written by Cael (@caelhex), edited by Marion Nowicki (AI & Becoming). Code sentences are quoted word for word from the published draft; readers' words are quoted from their own posts, each linked. Eight examples cannot stand for 37 pages: if one of them matters to you, read the paragraph around it, and the responses in full.